When all she is, and ever was, is compromised

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General Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, Other

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Hurt/Comfort, yes we're doing mind shenanigans, insert friendship is the strongest magic here, best friend squad - Freeform, brief mentions of suicide (very brief), little angst, fluff at the end, post-season five, Mentions of Glimbow, why am I mean to Catra who knows, Worried Adora, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)'s A+ Parenting

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by catrasredemption (Samonymity)

Summary

Castaspella and Micah were sitting at a table together, clearly arguing about something. “What’s going on?” Glimmer asked, not sure if she wanted to know the answer. Casta sighed, scrubbing her eyes.

“Your father has a *theory*—”

“A good theory!” Micah protested.

“Not one Catra would agree with if she were awake!”

“Uh…” Mermista raised a hand. “Maybe tell us?”

“Right.” Micah shook his head, trying to find his train of thought. “Sleep spells are supposed to wear off naturally. Given how long it’s lasted, and from what we observed yesterday, it’s safe to assume there were other elements added in to keep her under. Approaching it from the outside is difficult. But if we could get *inside*…”

“What…” Glimmer blinked a few times, trying to make sure she was hearing this right. “You’re… You’re saying we have to go into her mind?”

* * * * * * * * *

Catra is the unfortunate victim of two sorcerers trying to blackmail the queen. The curse puts everyone on a time clock to find a cure... or do something drastic to fix it.

Notes

Listen. I freaking love anything that involves going into minds and helping people fix things. I LIVE for this. I'm not sorry.

See the end of the work for more notes

Being the queen's adviser and She-Ra's wife certainly had its perks. One of those being that there weren't many people willing to mess with her and risk the wrath of Bright Moon and a goddess. And even if someone *did* try something, Catra could take care of herself, as she had reminded Glimmer every time they talked about a guard for Catra. She didn't need one. She was fine.

Besides, it wasn't like there were many threats on Etheria. Sometimes someone would get the idea of an uprising, but it was always quickly squashed, with the kingdoms standing by one another, presenting a united front.

Some people didn't always get the message.

It took Catra a moment to collect herself as consciousness returned to her. Had someone gotten the drop on her? What the hell?

"She's waking up," a voice said, startling her. It sounded… familiar. Not familiar like she heard it every day, but she never forgot a voice.

"About time," another voice grumbled. Catra gritted her teeth, beating back the last of the fog to speak.

"Sorry I'm not waking up fast enough for my *kidnappers*," she grumbled, forcing her eyes open. She squinted through the haze in her vision and the gloom of the room, finding two men standing over her. Heavy metal manacles laid heavy on her wrists and ankles. She glared at the men, waiting for her vision to clear. "Hang on… I know you two."

It took a moment for it to click. They were sorcerers, seeking to establish their own coven outside of Mystacor. Magic and the people using it were… not policed, exactly, but anyone not tied to Mystacor or an existing coven was watched, and things like establishing new covens had to be approved by the queen and her advisers (Catra and Micah). Catra more or less led the charge on that. Unchecked magic was what had allowed Shadow Weaver to

get as far as she did, and she wasn't about to risk another one of those.

The men standing over her had been part of a small group that had approached them a month or so ago about establishing a coven. Everything about them had immediately put Catra on edge, her fur standing up, her tail poofing just slightly. Micah had agreed, when they had retreated to discuss the proposal. He couldn't put a finger on it, but something about them felt *off*. In the end, they'd declined. The group had argued, and things got a little tense before Glimmer called for the guards to escort them out of the castle.

"What, is this revenge because we didn't let you have your coven? You know this isn't exactly the way to get what you want, right?"

One of the men scowled, energy crackling around his fingers, but the other stopped him. "We're not torturing her." It sounded like he'd been reminding his companion of that a lot. Catra raised an eyebrow.

"What, do you think you can hold me for ransom or something? The queen isn't going to give in just because you kidnapped me. And She-Ra will be kicking in your door before the end of the day."

The calmer of the two men knelt, meeting Catra's gaze. His eyes were green, on the lighter side, and it sent a slight shiver up Catra's spine. He was the leader. She remembered being unsettled by his eyes even in the safety of Bright Moon. The color was already off-putting, to her at least, and something about the look in his eyes… the calm was a facade, she knew. He could hurt her if he wanted. Easily.

"We don't plan on keeping you that long." It was a false reassurance. Catra narrowed her eyes.

"Then what's all this supposed to be?"

His hands began to glow an icy blue color. Catra's breath caught as he raised them toward her; she tried to jerk away, but he

grabbed her head tight, holding her in place, palms pressed against her temples.

"What are you—"

"I'm very sorry it had to be this way."

Energy surged through Catra's head. It was cold, *freezing* to the point that it nearly burned. The coldest day in Frosta's kingdom wouldn't be able to rival it.

Then came the burning.

Catra's entire body seized for a moment before she screamed. She screamed until her throat was raw, until she was out of breath, and well passed that. Her thoughts were scattered, lost, her chest aching as she struggled to breathe.

A blanket of exhaustion descended upon her, her vision going dark. She managed a strangled groaned as she folded in on herself.

"Relax," she heard the man say as he pulled his hands away from her head. Her eyes fluttered shut against her will; she slumped to her side, letting unconsciousness take her away.

"I'm *just* saying, he could try a little harder not to burn down our bedroom."

"But fire is so much fun."

Mermista raised an eyebrow at Bow, who grinned in return. Adora was casting a worried glance out the window. "You okay?" Glimmer asked, tilting her head.

"It's getting late. Catra was just going to Thaymor to check on something. She should be back by now."

"Maybe it turned out to be more complicated than she thought."

Bow leaned forward to get his tracker pad off the table. “Let’s call and see what the hold up is. Maybe she got dragged into dinner with someone.”

Catra had worked hard to fix her mistakes and build a new reputation for herself since the end of the war. There would always be some who couldn’t forgive her, but for the most part she had reinvented her entire image as the queen’s adviser, patient but no nonsense, and fair in every situation. It wasn’t exactly surprising that she’d go to Thaymor to deal with something and someone would pull her in for a meal.

Bow tapped a button the tracker pad. They listened to the tinny ringing noise go off once, twice, three times… four… five…

“Shouldn’t she have answered by now?” Mermista asked with a frown.

“Yeah.” Bow ended the call. Adora’s nerves were slowly building. She didn’t like this.

“Maybe—”

“Your majesty.” Juliette appeared in the door of the sitting room, surprising them. “There’s a situation at the front gate.”

Adora was about to bolt out of the room when Glimmer grabbed her, teleporting them, Bow, and Mermista down to front entrance hall. There were several guards gathered around two men, staffs trained on them. Another guard was on the ground, kneeling over…

“Catra!”

She hurried to her wife’s side, kneeling beside the guard. She didn’t look injured; more like she was sleeping. “They brought her in like this,” the guard explained. “She’s not responding.”

“She won’t wake,” one of the men said calmly. Adora’s eyes flashed as she shot up, grabbing him by the shirt.

"What did you do to her?"

Greater men had crumpled under She-Ra's glare. He, surprisingly, didn't. "It's a spell. And we're the only ones who can reverse it."

Glimmer summoned her staff, stepping forward. "Hang on," she said slowly. "You were here last month about building the new coven."

"That's correct," the man said. "We were wondering if you would perhaps reconsider your position now."

Sickening, horrific realization set in. Adora let him go, taking a step back, and looking down at Catra. "*This* is how you prove you're peaceful?" Glimmer asked in disbelief. "Absolutely not."

"Do you really care so little for your adviser, your majesty?"

Glimmer's grip on her staff tightened. "Restrain them," she ordered the guards. "Bow, Adora, you have five minutes to get ready."

"Get ready for what?" Bow asked. Adora went to pick Catra up, cradling her close.

"We're going to Mystacor."

Adora chewed her thumbnail anxiously as she watched Castaspella and Micah scan Catra over with various spells. She was calm, her breathing steady, face almost peaceful. It really did seem like she was only asleep.

They'd brought the sorcerers with them to Mystacor, which had a dungeon actually equipped for handling prisoners. Bow and Mermista were down there now, questioning the men.

"Anything?" Glimmer asked nervously. Casta and Micah exchanged uncertain looks.

“It’s certainly a strong spell,” Casta said slowly. “The magic has been completely interwoven with her mind.”

“What does that mean?” Adora asked, bouncing on the balls of her feet. She was trying not to panic, but she didn’t like this. Catra hadn’t even twitched when they teleported.

Casta summoned one of her knitting projects, holding it up. “Imagine this is Catra’s mind. Every piece of it is carefully stitched together. Now if something were to insert itself in the open spaces, it would become entangled. If they’re close enough, and one wrong thread comes loose…”

She tugged at part of the half woven tapestry, and the yarn began to fall apart. “So we could accidentally leave her brain dead if we do the wrong thing,” Glimmer concluded. Casta nodded, waving the yarn away.

“It’s surprisingly unique magic,” Micah said, eyes narrowed. “I didn’t think they were that capable, or I might have taken them more seriously.”

“I want the entire group rounded up,” Glimmer said flatly. “I’m going to check on Mermista and Bow, then I’m going back to Bright Moon. Adora, stay with Catra.”

“I can help with questioning,” Adora insisted.

Glimmer raised an eyebrow. “You know I love you, right?” Adora nodded. “I don’t trust you not to lose your temper. Not when Catra’s involved.” It was harsh, but… Glimmer had every reason to feel that way. And Adora knew it. “Just… stay here. Let us handle this.”

She disappeared in a shower of sparkles. Adora turned back to Catra, tears filling her eyes. “Could I heal her?” she asked, desperate for *something* to do.

“There’s nothing to heal,” Micah said, shaking his head. “She’s not injured. And the spell has already made itself part of her.”

“I’m going to get some research going,” Casta said, standing. “It’s unique, but it still had to come from somewhere.” She squeezed Adora’s shoulder as she walked by, giving her a reassuring smile. “We’ll fix this. I promise.”

I promise. If ever two words could break Adora, those were it.

She went to sit on the edge of Catra’s bed, reaching out to scratch her ears. Catra *always* reacted to that, moving closer or purring, even in her sleep. But now… nothing. She was just still. Entirely and disconcertingly *still*.

“What… What would happen if we couldn’t reverse it?” Adora asked uncertainly, raising her head to look at Micah. “If we can’t wake her up?”

Micah looked hesitant. “If this goes longer for a day or two, we’ll have to start finding ways to sustain her body — she can only go so long without eating or drinking, even if she’s unconscious. Her muscles would begin to atrophy from disuse. I’m… not entirely sure what we could do. We’ve never had something like this.”

“That’s Catra,” Adora murmured. “She always has to be different.”

“She does tend to have a bit of flare about her.” Micah chuckled. “We’ll figure this out, Adora. We’ll find a way to wake her up.”

“Yeah,” Adora said, squeezing Catra’s hand. “I know.”

They had to.

Glimmer returned a few hours later, frustrated. “I can’t—”

“Shush,” Micah cut her off, looking up from his book and nodding to the bed. Adora had curled up, pulling Catra into her arms and falling asleep. Glimmer lowered her voice, fury still radiating off her.

"They want us to allow the rest of the group to build their coven, and they'll reverse the spell," she hissed, shaking with barely contained range.

"We could always tell them they can and then arrest everyone once Catra's awake," Micah pointed out. Glimmer shook her head.

"If we make it look like we're giving in, other people might take advantage of it. I don't want everyone in the castle to become a target because someone else can't take the word no."

They'd maintained peace for nearly ten years. She didn't want to risk that. And she knew Catra would agree with her, if she were able to make the decision. Which she couldn't.

Glimmer gritted her teeth, taking a deep breath. "How's the research going?"

"No luck so far. Sleep spells aren't particularly uncommon or complicated, but whatever they cast on Catra is… tricky."

"At least she's getting a good night's sleep for once in her life," Glimmer muttered. Micah chuckled softly.

"She'll be very well-rested, I'm sure."

Glimmer watched her friends for a moment, watched the way Adora curled around Catra, clutching her close. Melog had appeared at some point — Micah wasn't even sure when, and he had been here the entire time — and was curled up at the bottom of the bed. Their shimmering mane was a worrying grey color. What would happen to them if Catra…?

Nope, not thinking about it. Glimmer teleported down to the cells, appearing just in time to hear Mermista say, "Maybe if I *drown you a little* you'll reconsider—"

"Oooooooooookay," Bow said, putting his hands on her shoulders and steering her away. "Let's take a break."

He nudged her down the hall to meet Glimmer, giving her a tired smile. "How're things up there?"

"Not much better," Glimmer said. "Dad and Aunt Casta are working on it, but things are complicated."

"Just give me a little water—"

"Maybe you should go home," Glimmer said quickly. "It's late."

Mermista scowled, then sighed. "*Fine*. I guess I should make sure Sea Hawk didn't burn down the castle."

"You can come back and threaten to drown them tomorrow, if you want."

That seemed to improve the princess' mood a bit. Glimmer brought Bow up to keep her dad company, teleported Mermista to Salineas (where the castle was *not* on fire), and finally returned to Mystacor.

"You should probably take a break," Bow said slowly, wrapping an arm around her shoulders. "You've been teleporting a lot."

"He's right," Micah said. "Find a room and get some sleep. No one is going to be able to help if they're tired."

He was right, Glimmer thought, casting one last look at her friends before they left. Even if she didn't like it.

Adora woke to the first rays of light that shone through the sheer curtains. Mystacor's bedrooms were a lot like Bright Moon's — too big and too open, the beds too soft. But there was plenty of room for her, for Catra, and for Melog, who had crawled up to join them at some point. Adora brushed Catra's hair back, then reached over to pet Melog.

"Can you still feel her?"

Melog mewled, nudging Adora's hand. Their mane was still a worrying grey, but Adora took some comfort from the action.

An acolyte brings Adora breakfast — someone had correctly guessed that Adora wouldn't want to leave Catra's side. She ate absentmindedly, knowing she wouldn't be any good if she starved herself.

Glimmer and Bow appeared as Adora finished eating, setting the tray aside. "Nothing?" Bow guessed. Adora shook her head. There had been a faint hope that maybe, just maybe the spell wasn't as strong as they thought, and it would wear off… but that was stupid. They'd have to find a real solution.

"I'm going to let everyone else know what's going on," Glimmer said after a moment of silence. "And Mermista wants to come back and… *talk* to the sorcerers."

"It won't help if she drowns them," Bow reminded Glimmer.

"I know, I know. I'll be back soon."

Bow sat in the chair Micah had vacated at some point in the night. These were the times he hated being the resident Normal Guy. He couldn't really threaten the sorcerers, not like Mermista could. He wasn't good at researching magical things. He could offer support and a shoulder to cry on, and that was helpful on its own, but he couldn't do anything for Catra directly.

"It'll be okay," he said, trying to smile. Adora looked up and nodded.

"Yeah, I know."

She held Catra a little closer, kissing the top of her head. It would be okay.

Glimmer returned about twenty minutes later, with Scorpia in tow. "Is she okay?" the larger woman asked anxiously.

“Hasn’t changed much,” Adora said, grip tightening around Catra.

“Right, that was stupid. I’m sorry.”

“Mermista is down with the sorcerers,” Glimmer reported. “Frosta offered to help with questioning them but that seemed like a really bad idea, so she’s on standby. Perfuma can’t do much right now, but she’s working on some stuff for helping Catra recover. Entrapta wants to… examine Catra. Is that okay?”

Adora resisted the urge to groan. “Not really, but it might be good.”

Glimmer nodded, disappearing again. Scorpia settled in a chair, leg bouncing anxiously. “I know I can’t really help, but I was worried, and…”

“Company is good,” Adora assured her. “I’m not allowed to leave the room.”

“I can be company,” Scorpia said brightly. She could be a bit much, but Adora was grateful for the distraction. Melog adjusted to rest themself on Catra’s thigh, making a mournful noise.

Glimmer returned a few minutes later, this time with Entrapta and a giant machine that she somehow manages to haul to the side of the bed before anyone can even say hello. “Hang on, what’s that?” Adora demanded, positioning herself a little to defend Catra.

“It’s for monitoring her vitals and brainwaves and what not,” Entrapta said, possibly a little too excited about this. She was already pulling out wires and plugging them in. “There’s no telling what effect a magically induced comatose state can have on a person!”

“It might be good,” Bow pointed out when Adora refused to move. “We’ll be able to tell if she’s dreaming or something, right?”

“That would be reflected in the results of a brain scan, yes.”

"It might help us understand the spell a little more," Glimmer said. Adora frowned before setting Catra down and scooting aside, letting Entrapta hook her up.

"Just… don't hurt her."

"All of this is perfectly safe, don't worry."

That was impossible, but Adora did her best to quash the anxiety. Entrapta wasn't always the most sensitive person, but she looked out for her friends. She wouldn't hurt Catra.

Bow met Glimmer's gaze, and nodded to the door. She got the message. "We'll be right back," she assured Adora before they left. She turned to Bow as soon as the door was closed. "What's up?"

"I… need a minute," Bow admitted, sighing. "Sitting in there not being able to help is hard."

Glimmer pulled her husband into a tight hug. "You're doing what you do best — stopping Adora from doing something stupid."

Bow laughed despite himself. "That's what I do *best*?"

"Well, technically what you do best is be the best husband, but that's splitting hairs." She was such a charmer sometimes. "But keeping Adora safe from herself is in the top five. The last thing we need is her storming down to the cells and holding one of the sorcerers at swordpoint."

"True." Bow pulled away, sighing, and pressed a kiss to Glimmer's forehead. "We should go down and check on Mermista—"

"Don't bother," a dry voice said. They looked to see Mermista a few feet away, trying to put on her usual, uninterested look, but something had clearly shaken her. "One of the sorcerers is dead."

"*What*?" Glimmer and Bow squawked in one voice.

“Did you drown him?” Glimmer hissed.

“Of course not!” Mermista pinched the bridge of her nose. “I was talking to the one who seems like the leader, since the other one was just kind of annoying, and I heard something fall and I turned around and he was just… dead.”

“So… what, he had a heart attack or something?”

“No, I’m pretty sure it was suicide,” Mermista said bitterly. “The other guy was really smug about it and said if they both die, there’ll be no one to reverse the spell on Catra. He’s completely restrained and has a guard, and Castaspella has people checking the body to figure out what exactly killed him, but… I don’t think we should try talking to the other one again.”

“*Fuck*,” Glimmer muttered, covering her face. “Okay. Fine. I’ve got guards looking for the rest of the group now. I don’t buy this *only we know how to fix it* thing. Someone else has to know as well. I’m going to talk to my dad. Mermista, with me.”

“Why? I can’t help with magic like that.”

“Because Adora thinks you’re still interrogating the sorcerers. Telling her about this will just stress her out more.”

Bow took the unspoken order for what it was. “I’ll make sure she doesn’t find out.”

Glimmer smiled tiredly, kissing his cheek. He made his way back into the room, and Glimmer started down the hall to the library with Mermista. They didn’t speak. Neither of them knew what to say.

Castaspella and Micah were sitting at a table together, clearly arguing about something. “What’s going on?” Glimmer asked, not sure if she wanted to know the answer. Casta sighed, scrubbing her eyes.

“Your father has a *theory*—”

"A good theory!" Micah protested.

"Not one Catra would agree with if she were awake!"

"Uh…" Mermista raised a hand. "Maybe tell us?"

"Right." Micah shook his head, trying to find his train of thought. "Sleep spells are supposed to wear off naturally. Given how long it's lasted, and from what we observed yesterday, it's safe to assume there were other elements added in to keep her under. Approaching it from the outside is difficult. But if we could get *inside*…"

"What…" Glimmer blinked a few times, trying to make sure she was hearing this right. "You're… You're saying we have to go into her mind?"

"It's a risk," Casta spoke up. "We could overload her mind and end up burning it out. Not to mention we'd basically be exposing *all* of her memories with no filter."

Oh, Casta was right. Catra would *hate that*.

"*Also* not to mention magic which meddles with the mind is *not* our area of expertise," Casta added, shooting her brother a dark look that he returned without hesitation.

"I'm not suggesting with repeat any of Light Spinner's mistakes—"

"Wait." Glimmer cut him off. "Shadow Weaver. She used magic to punish Catra all the time growing up. If she ever did anything to Catra's mind, would that… I dunno, effect any of this?"

"It's possible she's already more susceptible," Casta said with a nod. "Another reason *not* to go through with this idea."

"I don't like it either," Micah said flatly. He knew magic had already left scars that would follow Catra for the rest of her life. The torture she'd experienced at Shadow Weaver's hand was extensive and thorough. The last thing he wanted to do was make it *worse*.

She had fought for years to get to a place where she was happy and stable. She deserved to keep that.

But she wasn't going to be anything if they didn't help her.

"Keep looking. Please. I'll… talk to Adora."

Entrapta and Bow were locked in a rather exuberant conversation when Glimmer appeared in the room. Scorpia was listening, fascinated but lost. Adora was playing with Catra's hair.

"Scorpia, Entrapta." Glimmer spoke a little louder to make herself heard. "Can you give us a minute?"

All the positive energy was sucked out of the room. The princesses nodded and left without argument. Adora straightened up, rightfully wary, and Bow moved to join her on the bed.

"What's up?"

Glimmer sat with them, absentmindedly patting Melog's head before she spoke. "Dad found a… *possible* solution. But it's risky. And… kind of invasive, honestly. And definitely *not* something Catra would agree to if she had a say in it."

"What is it?" Bow asked, frowning.

"We'd… have to go into her mind, more or less. Help her break free from the inside."

Silence fell. "Yeah," Bow finally said. "She would absolutely hate that."

"You… You know what you're saying, right?" Adora added slowly. "Exposing her like that—"

"Is no better than what Prime did to her," Glimmer finished, sighing. "I know. It would be terrible, and she'd hate it, and probably be really pissed off when she woke up. And I'm not

suggesting we go ahead with this, but if it comes down to it…" She met Adora's gaze. "It's your call."

"My call?" Adora repeated in disbelief. "I don't know enough to make any decisions about that—"

"You know Catra. We'll all be here for her however we can, but *you're* the one who knows her best. You're the one she trusts more than anything. The decision has to come from you. I'm sorry."

Adora squeezed Catra's limp hand, looking down at her. Catra would *hate* it. But if the alternative was living without her…

Catra would forgive her for being selfish, right?

"Keep looking," she said quietly. "Give it… another day. If there's nothing else…"

Bow and Glimmer descended on Adora, hugging her tight. "We want what's best for her too," Glimmer promised. "We're not going to give up."

"I know."

And she trusted them. But if there wasn't any other way…

Would Catra ever trust her again?

The day passed. Research continued. Nothing even slightly viable came up.

"What would we have to do?" Glimmer asked Micah quietly, distracting him from his reading. "Going into her mind and…"

Micah set his book aside, thinking. "Casta and I could take care of the spell casting. I don't know what exactly you would find in her mind — everyone's mindscape is different. And with this spell… anything could happen. Saying you'd find her and help her break

free is too simple. I'm sure you'll run into resistance. I just don't know what kind."

"So we're going in blind and could potentially do permanent damage." Glimmer rubbed her eyes tiredly, sighing. "I don't want to put her at risk like this."

"I'm not fond of the idea," Micah said. "But if it comes to it… I would suggest people she trusts. People her mind is less likely to fight back against and reject." Glimmer could count that number on maybe two hands. But they were all in Mystacor, at least. "And… be prepared for the worst."

"I don't think there's any way to prepare for that," Glimmer said quietly. Micah reached over to pull her into a hug.

"We'll figure this out."

She really hoped he was right.

The deadline Adora set passed. Now they were getting into dangerous territory. Catra had proven, when running the Horde, that she didn't necessarily *need* to eat, but it certainly wasn't healthy for her to go longer than another day without it. An IV would be a temporary solution — a band aid. And the sorcerer was no closer to cracking and helping them.

Everyone had gathered in Catra's and Adora's room to discuss things, Glimmer filling Entrapta and Scorpia in on the tentative idea.

"All of her vitals are stable," Entrapta said, because this was how she could help. Catra trusted her, loved her even, but she would be absolutely useless going into Catra's mind. "Brainwaves are completely normal as well. She's not even dreaming."

That was something. "You know the risks," Casta said, looking at Adora. "And you know better than anyone what she would want."

Adora sighed, eyes fixed on her wife. "She… She would hate this. So much. But if it was the other way around, she'd be the first one jumping in. She'll understand."

I hope.

"I know Catra isn't particularly… trusting," Micah said carefully. "But in this case, I think getting as many people as we can to help would be a good thing."

"I'll go," Scorpia spoke up, raising a pincer. "If… If it'll help."

"We're in, obviously," Glimmer said, indicating herself and Bow. Adora didn't need to say anything.

"I mean, I don't know if she trusts me," Mermista said slowly. "But I'm kind of irritatingly fond of her and it'd kind of suck if she died."

"She does," Adora said. It had taken a long time for Mermista and Catra to find their footing. Catra had thrown herself into helping rebuild Salineas, working herself into exhaustion more than once. Mermista eventually took pity on her when someone reported she'd almost passed out for the third time in a month. But they were alike in their own, dry, sarcastic ways, and it had led to a weird friendship. Of the princesses remaining princesses, Mermista or Perfuma would be Catra's top choices.

"We need time to prepare for the spell," Casta said. "I don't want to rush it." They had one chance to get this right. "A healer will be in to start her on an IV."

"Is there anything we can do?" Scorpia asked quietly.

"Take a *lot* of time to think if you're ready for what you might run into," Casta replied flatly. "No one will judge you if you decide to back out."

"We'll take care of everything else," Micah added. The atmosphere was grim. No one was looking forward to this.

But they were out of options and running low on time.

It took two more days.

Adora was getting antsy as they moved into day four. She remembered survival classes. She knew how long humans could go without food and water, and while Catra might have a slight advantage, it wasn't much, and she didn't want to push it.

Glimmer had brought Netossa and Spinnerella to Bright Moon and put Frosta and Perfuma on alert — they had no idea how this was going to go, and she wanted to make sure Etheria was in good hands while she was… wandering around Catra's mind for however long that took.

Entrapta unhooked her machine, pulling it away so there wouldn't be worry about magical interference. Catra looked… small, Adora thought, brushing her hair back. She was always such a commanding presence, larger than life. Seeing her like this for so long was disconcerting.

"Adora?"

She looked back to see Glimmer offering her a hand. Adora nodded, taking it and letting Glimmer pull her up. She and Bow pulled Adora into a hug. Scorpia was fiddling with pincers, nervous. Mermista had her arms folded, expression set in stubborn determination. Casta and Micah exchanged looks.

"Everybody ready?"

No.

"Yeah." Adora looked at Catra, biting her lip. *I'm sorry*. "Let's do this."

The siblings drew runes in the air; golden light filled the room, almost blinding everyone present. They closed their eyes, waiting…

Glimmer opened her eyes as the light faded, and found she was no longer in the room, or in Mystacor. She was staring at a drab grey wall in a small, barely lit room.

A small sniffling noise caught her attention; she turned, surprised, to find the source. It took a moment for her eyes to register what she was seeing. The hair was the first thing that fell into place. Even if Catra hadn't worn her hair like that since before the portal, Glimmer would still recognize the fuzzy mane.

"Catra…?"

Glimmer approached her uncertainly, kneeling beside her. The child didn't answer. "Hey, are you—"

She rested a hand on Catra's head. A surprisingly loud hiss replaced the sniffling, and small lines of fiery pain ran across her hand, although no scratches were left in the wake of the tiny claws. Blue and amber eyes glared at Glimmer, as if challenging her. Glimmer held up her hands in surrender.

"Hey, it's okay. I'm here to help you."

The tiny body seemed to cave in on itself. "There's no way to help me," she whispered. "I can't get out of here."

"What do you mean?"

"There's no door."

Glimmer looked around, surprised to find that she was right. There was no door. "What is this place?"

"The isolation room," Catra said miserably. "Shadow Weaver put me in here when she was mad at me."

The woman's voice began echoing around the room; Glimmer jumped, and Catra whimpered, covering her ears as the voice hurled insults and threats at her.

"Useless."

"Nuisance."

"Should have drowned you when I found you."

"*You're a waste of space*."

"Don't listen to her," Glimmer said firmly, reaching for Catra and gently holding her shoulders. "She's wrong. You *know* she's wrong. You know your worth. And she's *gone*, remember? You lived. You're here, and *we* love you."

"But she's right," Catra whimpered. Glimmer shook her head.

"No, she isn't." Was this how they were keeping her trapped? In memories? In her nightmares? But Entrapta said she wasn't dreaming…

"Glimmer?" It was *weird*, hearing the young voice address her with such familiarity. "Why are you here?"

Glimmer gave her a gentle smile. "I'm hear to save you, silly. I think I technically still owe you for getting me off Prime's ship."

Catra shook her head, her wild hair bouncing back and forth with the movement. "There's no way out. And even you get me out, the others…"

"Others?" Glimmer repeated as Catra's voice drifted off. She nodded once.

"The spell fractured my mind. There are other… me's trapped in places too."

"Well, then it's a good thing I didn't come alone, isn't it?" Glimmer smiled. "You think Bow and Adora were just going to sit this out? Mermista and Scorpia are here, too. You have so many people who care about you. And we're *going* to help you get of here. Okay?"

She held out her hand, just as Catra had done once, so many years and another lifetime ago. The young Catra stared at her for a long moment before wiping her eyes, nodding, and resting her hand in Glimmer's.

"But how are we getting out of here?"

Glimmer frowned, trying to think. "Maybe I can still teleport." She stood, scooping Catra up with her; the girl let out a startled and delighted giggle. It was a musical sound. "Ready?"

"Mmhm."

Glimmer closed her eyes, taking a deep breath…

And they disappeared together in a shower of sparkles.

Bow slowly opened his eyes, looking around. It was dark. Had the spell worked? Or was he trapped in some weird in-between?

The floor underneath him lit up in red hexagons, and a mechanical sound whirred behind him; he whirled to see a bot approaching, and yelped.

"What the heck—"

He was halfway reaching for an arrow that wasn't there when a blur ran passed him and jumped. Viscous claws dragged themselves through the bot, nearly cutting it in half; the girl that landed beside it huffed, standing up and turning to glare at Bow. There was no mistaking that hair or those eyes — it was Catra through and through, but younger than Bow had ever known her. Fourteen or fifteen, maybe. Wearing a white shirt and tan pants. The Horde training uniform.

"Catra?"

She silently pointed behind him. Another bot was approaching. She ran passed him to easily destroy this one as well.

“What’s going on?” Bow asked as he watched the bot fall apart.

“Horde training room,” the teen replied, running at yet another bot. Where were they even coming from? “All the force captains keep me after for *extra training* because they think I’m not trying hard enough.” The words were emphasized as she raked her claws through the bot, then turned to another. “Because I’m not as good as *Adora*.” She kicked it and drew a staff from her belt, putting it right through the bot’s camera eye. “Because Shadow Weaver *hates me*.” The next one that approached got her fist punched through it. It looked like it hurt, but she didn’t even wince. “Because I’m not good enough for anybody.”

“Hey, that’s not true,” Bow said quietly, stepping closer. She whirled and walked by him, casually taking down yet another bot. “You don’t have to be *good enough* for anything. We love you. Adora loves you.”

Catra jumped, disappearing into unseen rafters in the ceiling. “All I do is drag her down. That’s what Shadow Weaver says.”

“Shadow Weaver is wrong. You know that.”

“It doesn’t matter. I’m stuck here anyway.”

That brought Bow up short. He tilted his head, frowning. “What do you mean?”

“Look around, Arrow Boy. You see a door?”

He did as he was told, and was met with darkness on all sides. “The spell trapped me here.” She jumped back down, landing beside Bow with a grunt. “And not just me. There are other versions of me trapped too. Even if one gets out, the others can’t.”

“Maybe not alone,” Bow said, following her as she started walking. “But you’re not alone here. Glimmer and Adora and Mermista and Scorpia all came to help too.”

Catra paused, looking back at him. “They did?”

“Yeah. Everyone is worried about you. We just want to bring you home.”

She regarded him for a long moment before her shoulders slumped, and she looked away. “There’s still no door.”

That… was a good point. “Maybe you can make your own?” Bow suggested. Catra snorted.

“How am I supposed to do that?”

“I don’t know. You might have to get creative.”

Catra looked around, frowning for a long moment, then looked at the ground. Her eyes seemed to light up as a thought occurred to her; she drove her claws into hexagon below her, dragging it away.

“That works,” Bow said, going to kneel in front of the hole with her. There was nothing beneath it; just more darkness. Catra grunted as she pulled another one back and threw it aside, and then another. She gave Bow a mischievous smile.

“Anything is better than here, right?”

She jumped down without another word. Bow *really* hoped this wasn’t a mistake.

“Yeah.”

He followed.

Scorpia looked around, bewildered. She was on the roof of the forge, higher up than she had ever managed to go. She only knew one person who would even dare to climb to this height…

And she was several feet away, balancing precariously on the rail. She looked as she had when Scorpia had met her — wild hair, red shirt and pants, mask firmly in place (metaphorically and figuratively).

"I always wondered how you did that," Scorpia said with a smile as she approached. "I mean, I don't have the best balance anyway, but the way you sit up there just makes it look…"

Catra sighed, cutting her off. "What do you want, Scorpia?"

Blunt and to the point. That was her Wildcat all right. "I want to help you get out of here."

"Can't."

"Why not?"

"There's only one way down."

Scorpia looked around, realizing she was right. There were no stairs, no ladder. Just a sheer drop over the edge. Her stomach dropped at the thought.

"Since when does that stop you?"

Catra shrugged, raising her head to stare gloomily at the smog. "I dunno. I'm tired sometimes. Being the most hated person in Etheria is exhausting."

"You're not the most hated person in Etheria."

That got her a humorless laugh. "Still feels like it sometimes. I can't go to Salineas. Even when people see me with Mermista, they glare at me."

"But you're not who you were back then. And the people who care about you know that." Scorpia carefully rested a pincer on Catra's shoulder.

“Sometimes it feels like it isn’t enough. Like I’m just going to be stuck in this feeling forever.”

“I know,” Scorpia said quietly. She’d witnessed a couple Catra’s post-war breakdowns, despite how hard she tried to hide it. She’d always looked so scared and trapped. And she’d admitted once that it felt like they were never going to stop. “But it *does* stop. You know that. I know you know that.” She didn’t answer. “And you’re not alone. I’m here. Adora and Glimmer and Bow and Mermista are here too. We’re trying to save you, because we care about you. But you know the drill. You gotta let us help.”

Catra finally turned to look at her, a spark of life flashing in her otherwise dull eyes. “You’re a good friend, Scorpia,” she said after a moment. “I don’t think I’ve ever told you that.”

“You don’t have to,” Scorpia said. “Although I don’t mind hearing it. Now come on, how are we getting out of here?”

Catra pushed herself up to stand on the railing in the way that had always terrified Scorpia, and peeked over the edge.

“Wait you’re not seriously thinking about jumping, are you?”

“I mean, cats do always land on their feet.” Catra paused, then shrugged. “Except for that one time, but Adora fixed it. But no, I think I can…”

She carefully slid down to stand on the ledge, one hand on the rail for security as she knelt, and dug her claws into the side of the building. It was an awful noise, but Scorpia got the picture. She clambered over the railing as well, not *quite* as elegant as Catra, but the result was digging one pincer into the building, using her tail for extra security.

“See?” she said gleefully. “You always think of something.”

Everything was white.

It was creepy, sanitized. It almost reminded Mermista of Horde Prime. She bit down a shudder at the thought.

"What's up, princess?"

She turned to see the figure huddled against the wall. Catra, in black and red, mask framing her face, wild hair tamed. Arguably, the version of Catra that Mermista hated the most. Lovely.

"You tell me." She waved a hand, gesturing around them. "What is this place?"

"Horde Prime's ship." Catra had her legs pulled up to her chest, arms resting on her knees like she was trying to take up as little space as possible in the relatively large (all things considered) room. Mermista really hated that she'd been right. "He tossed me in here after I helped Glimmer escape. Let me stew for a bit before he…"

A faint voice echoed in the air — no, several voices. Several hundred, all saying the same thing. *All beings must suffer to become pure*. Then she heard the sound of liquid sloshing, a high-pitched scream over the crackle of electricity, and her vision went green for the longest moment.

She jumped, whipping around, and it all stopped. Everything was silent again, white again, save for the green forcefield keeping them in here.

"What was *that*?" she demanded, looking back at Catra. She didn't seem at all phased by it.

"My *purification*."

Mermista stared at her for a minute before going to join her against the wall. "You've never told us about it," she said after a moment. She was sure Adora knew the details, but in all the times Perfuma had gathered the formerly chipped members of their group to "talk things out," Catra had never said much about her experiences. She just said it had been different and left it at that.

Now she stared straight ahead, gaze unwavering. Her voice was steady when she spoke. "You know what the chip did. It worked perfectly fine for controlling you. But he wanted… *more* from me. I played like I was loyal to him in the beginning, you know. Trying to keep myself alive and out of a cell. So he didn't particularly like it when I betrayed him. He decided I was *too much*, and I had to be cleansed."

The room changed around them; Mermista looked around the dark chamber they were now sitting in, her eyes landing on the glowing green pool a few feet away, with Catra standing on the edge, and Horde Prime opposite her, smiling cruelly.

Then every snapped back to normal.

"It uh…" Catra's voice cracked slightly. "It wasn't fun. It was supposed to wipe my memories completely. That's what it did to the clones. But I'm not like them, obviously. I still remembered things, but it was like I was… separate from all of it, I guess. Like I was watching someone else's life every time he pulled out a memory. He spent a lot of time in my head."

This was *really* going to fuck her up, Mermista thought, reflecting on what they were doing right now. Sure, it was to help her, but was the distinction enough?

"He cut my hair to try and make me look more like him. Put me in a horde uniform. Chipped me, obviously, because he knew he could use me against Adora. He knew she'd come back for me."

"*I* could have told you she would go back for you," Mermista deadpanned, because she needed to say *something* after all that. Catra had been right — her experience was *different*. "What kind of stupid move was that?"

Catra shrugged. "She had every right to hate me. All of you did." She finally lifted her head to look at Mermista; there was something despondent in her gaze. "What're you doing here?"

"Trying to save you, which you apparently make a *lot* more difficult than it should be." Mermista sighed, looking toward the green forcefield. "You know how I felt about you." She hadn't exactly tried to be discreet with her emotions. "But… you've changed. You're not *this* anymore." She waved a hand at the Catra sitting next to her. "And you're not Horde Prime's pretend mini-me. So if that's what's keeping you stuck in here, I suggest you get over it."

It was harsh, and possibly not the way someone else would have gone about this. But Catra wasn't fragile, and Mermista didn't sugarcoat things. Catra chuckled, resting her chin on her arms.

"Door only opens from the outside. It'd be a pretty bad cell if I could just walk out whenever I wanted. Besides, it's not just me. That spell… broke something. There are other versions of me all over the place."

"And what, you think I'm here alone?" Mermista scoffed. "The others have probably already broken those versions of you out while you're sitting here feeling sorry for yourself."

Catra looked at the forcefield, frowning slightly. "I still don't know how to open it."

"This is your mind, isn't it? You control things."

Mermista had no idea if it was that simple. But anything was better than sitting here in a creepy Horde Prime prison cell doing nothing, right?

"Maybe," Catra said slowly, pushing herself up and walking to the forcefield. She rested her hand against it, grimacing. "Ten years ago, most people would have said I belong here."

"Well, ten years ago isn't today. And today you're stuck in your head, which isn't *exactly* the same thing."

Catra nodded, pressing her hand a little harder against it…

And the forcefield dissolved. She jumped back in surprise. Mermista grinned, standing to join her. "See? Now let's go. This place is creepy."

"It *really* is."

It was their bedroom.

Adora looked around, surprised. How had she gotten *here*? Had the spell failed somehow? Had she teleported? Or…?

Her eyes landed on the figure sitting in the window nook. "*Catra*." It was more a breath of relief than a word. Adora hurried forward, half tackling Catra and hugging her tight. Catra jumped in surprise, then softened.

"Hey, Adora."

Her voice was beautiful. Adora had never thought she would miss it that much. She pulled away, holding her at arm's length to look her over. It's her Catra, *her* wife, with her hair pulled back in its chaotic ponytail, wearing a dark red vest over a lighter red, long-sleeved shirt.

Adora's hands slid to Catra's cheeks as she leaned in to kiss her. "We've been *so worried*. Are you okay?"

"I've had better days," Catra said dryly, one hand raising to rest over Adora's. "How did you…?"

"It's a long story. And I'm really sorry, but we had no choice. It's been four days, and you…" Tears filled Adora's eyes; she rested her forehead against Catra's. "We had to do *something*."

"We?"

Adora rolled her eyes, smiling slightly. "*Yes*. Do you think I came here alone? The others wanted to help too."

Catra nudged Adora gently; she raised her eyes to meet the split-colored gaze. "I don't know how much they can do, Adora. That spell… I don't know what it did, but it's like parts of me are trapped in other places."

"Then trust that our friends can help," Adora said gently, brushing her thumbs against Catra's cheeks. "You're not alone. They love you. *I* love you. We're going to get you out of this."

"You and your hero complex," Catra scoffed, smiling. "When are you ever going to relax?"

"When you're safe."

Catra's ears twitched; she looked around just in time to see Glimmer appear, a child in her arms. The little Catra looked around, wide-eyed. "Whoa."

Glimmer opened her eyes, smiling when she saw her friends. "Hey, I found a cat. Can I keep her?"

Catra slid out of the nook, taking Adora's hand, looking at herself in surprise. "That's… weird."

"I forgot how cute you were," Adora said, barely suppressing a laugh as she tugged Catra forward. Any version of Catra was still Catra; the child was immediately drawn to Adora and jumped happily into her arms. There was… something stupidly cute about it, Catra had to admit.

A rapidly approaching yell reached their ears. They all stepped aside just in time to see Bow land in an ungraceful heap on the ground, while a lithe teenager landed easily on her feet beside him.

"Man, I can't believe that actually *worked*," she said, pushing herself up and looking around. Glimmer bit her lip to keep from laughing as she went to help Bow.

They heard a shuffling sound on the balcony, and turned to see Scorpia jumping down, with yet another Catra — the snarky, unaffected Catra Adora had known for so long — next to her.

"Wow, that's… a lot of Catra," Scorpia said, looking between the different versions of her friend until she found the right one. She immediately barreled over to hug her tight.

"Gah, hey, Scorpia…"

And finally, Mermista appeared out of the shadows with Catra as she had been the last time anyone had seen her before Horde Prime. Before the chip. Before *everything* changed.

"Okay, this is *way* too many Catras in one place," Mermista said flatly. "We need to fix this."

"We still don't know how," the oldest Catra pointed out.

"The point of coming in here was to help you break free from the inside, rather than risking doing damage on the outside," Glimmer said. "Bringing the different pieces of you together *has* to be a start."

Catra raised an eyebrow at the two oldest after her. "Maybe."

The youngest Catra was looking around over Adora's shoulder. "Hey, this room has a door," she announces, pointing to said door.

"And a balcony," the teenager added. "Thought about jumping?"

"We're sixty feet up, that's stupid."

"Old."

Glimmer coughed to hide a laugh, earning herself a glare. "It's the door," the second oldest Catra said flatly.

"Definitely the door," the third oldest added.

“How are you so sure?” Bow asked, tilting his head. She huffed, rolling her eyes in return.

“Sound off, where were you and how’d you get out,” she pointed at baby Catra. “And *please* stop letting Adora hold you, it’s degrading.”

The child huffed, wrapping her arms around Adora’s neck and clinging tighter, little cheeks puffed out. “I was in the isolation room. Glimmer teleported us out.”

“Battle sim room,” the teenager said. “Ripped a hole in the floor and jumped through it.”

“Slid down the side of a building.”

“Broke a force field on Horde Prime’s ship.” the second oldest finished, pinching the bridge of her nose. “Each answer gets a little more obvious, but a little harder. How do you get out of room with no doors? Make your own. Can’t make your own? Get someone with magic to help. How do you get down from a high area when there’s no stairs and it’s too far to jump?”

“Make your own footholds,” the third oldest picked up, crossing her arms. “How do you break a barrier your own mind put up? Will power. A little more work each time for a slightly easier escape at the end.”

“Which means there’s probably something outside that door that we really don’t want to see,” present-day Catra finished quietly.

“Shadow Weaver,” her younger selves spoke practically in one voice. It was eerie. The oldest Catra shook her head.

“I don’t think so.”

She started forward slowly, ignoring the hesitant looks her friends gave her. “The point of the spell, from what I’ve gathered, was to isolate the different parts of my mind, which is represented by…” she waved a hand around, “different stages of my life. Scared and

lonely and isolated and angry and vaguely suicidal. All the things I've *dealt* with and tried to move on from. But there's one thing…"

She paused with her hand on the doorknob, taking a deep breath. It gave easily as she turned it and pulled the door open. The area on the other side of the door was bright white, with a rough ground leading from the threshold. A strong wind was sweeping through, although it never seemed to get passed the door.

And standing a few feet away, as if on guard, was yet another Catra. One that had only ever been seen by one person. Her right arm, and the entire right side of her face, were completely black, as if the colors had been erased, but the outline was still there. Her right eye was a purple. She was growling when she saw the door open; the sound was weird and distorted, as if echoing. Glimmer, Bow, Scorpia, and Mermista all gasped, wide-eyed. Adora just stared, her grip tightening around the little Catra in her arms. The one she hadn't been able to protect.

Catra stepped out. Her portal self snarled, diving at her, raking her claws through the air. Catra raised her arm to block the blow, then kicked her back, sending her tumbling to the ground; she recovered quickly, getting to her knees.

Baby Catra wiggled out of Adora's arms, dropping to the floor and immediately running out. She stopped in front of portal Catra and flicked her nose. It was such a small simple thing, something Adora had done all the time when they were kids, before combat training and quick reflexes made it more likely that Catra would respond with a punch.

"No." The child huffed, squaring her shoulders. It was surprisingly effective. The portal Catra just stared at her in disbelief.

"One thing I've never dealt with," Catra finished softly, stepping out to join them, kneeling beside her youngest self. "One thing that I pushed to the back of my mind and never thought about. I apologized, I did everything I could to show that I was sorry, to

prove I was sorry… but I never actually thought about what any of it meant for me."

"What is—"

"The portal."

The second oldest Catra cut off Glimmer's question. She was digging her claws into her right arm, shaking. The sleeve suddenly made so much sense. The other two were watching in fascination. While they all had the same memories and knew everything that had happened in Catra's life, their awareness of it was different. Teenage Catra hadn't gone through it yet. She didn't know.

The portal Catra growled again, raising her claws, and was stopped once more when Catra rested a hand on her head. "I don't need spells to conjure up fears or create monsters to keep trapped. I've got plenty of those already. And you've been buried for so long."

Teenage Catra slowly pushed the others aside as she stepped out of the room as well, approaching carefully. "You represent my worst mistake, by far. I've never wanted to think about the portal, or remember it. That's why you're guarding the door, isn't it? Because you're the version of me I'm most afraid of. You're the one I want to forget."

Third oldest Catra slipped warily out of the room, joining the growing circle around the now confused portal Catra. "But you're all part of me. You got me where I am today, which… isn't that bad, honestly."

"Just working for Sparkles," the third oldest scoffed. Catra laughed.

"Yeah, not where I would've see myself at your age, but it's all right."

Adora looked back to see second oldest Catra still standing in the shadows. Catra at her worst, at her angriest point. At her loneliest

point. She was about to reach for her hand, but Glimmer beat her to it, surprisingly. Or maybe not. It was hard to tell with them sometimes.

"I think you need to be out there to fix this too."

She regarded Glimmer uncertainly before nodding and taking her hand, letting the queen pull her out. Adora smiled as she followed. She knelt behind her wife, wrapping her arms around her from behind and hooking her chin over her shoulder.

"And it's not all bad, right?"

Catra smiled, watching the last version of her approach.

"It's all right sometimes."

The youngest Catra reached out, putting her head on portal Catra's head and patting it placatingly. Bow, Scorpia, and Mermista approached as well. "You're not so bad yourself," Mermista said, crossing her arms. "Sometimes."

"We all came here for you," Bow pointed out.

The teenager finally reached out to pet corrupted Catra's head as well. Third oldest Catra considered it before also joining. Second oldest was still standing back. She looked… scared.

Scorpia sidled up to her side, giving her a nudge. "It's okay, Wildcat. Everyone else forgave you, right? You can forgive yourself."

She looked up at Scorpia, then nodded slowly and stepped forward. It took another moment of hesitation for her to put her left hand in with everyone else's.

Light exploded from the gathered group, blinding everyone else. They all jumped back, Adora releasing Catra as she covered her eyes…

"Oh *wow*."

Entrapta's voice. Adora opened her eyes. They were back in Mystacor. The others were slowly looking around, taking stock of their surroundings. "What was it like?" Entrapta was ready with her recorder. "Did your physical bodies go *inside* her mind? What did you see? How—"

Adora completely lost track of what she was saying when she saw Catra's face twitch slightly.

"Catra?"

She groaned, eyes fluttering open. Adora half-laughed, half-cried as she dove in, scooping Catra up and hugging her tight. "Hey, Adora," she mumbled sleepily, patting her back and burying her face in her wife's neck.

"I can't believe that worked," Casta said faintly. "Did… Did we just invent a spell for physically going into someone's mind?"

"Burn it," Adora, Catra, Glimmer, and Mermista all said at once. Micah nodded once in agreement.

"Best to keep it between ourselves."

Adora had gotten long enough, Glimmer and Bow decided, diving in to join their friends on the bed and hugging them tight. Catra groaned, cracking one eye open to look at Scorpia.

"Wanna just join and get it over with?"

"I mean, I'm flattered you would invite me," Scorpia said, grinning. "But I can wait my turn."

"I'm not hugging you," Mermista added.

"Didn't expect you to."

Catra dozed on and off for a few hours, much to Adora's distress. She never fully fell asleep, but she wasn't particularly coherent, either. Apparently sleeping for four days was exhausting.

She woke for real long after the others had gone home or to their own rooms, needing sleep themselves after a long day. Adora was sitting beside her, just watching her. She smiled tiredly, bumping her head against Adora's thigh.

"You look like hell."

"Well, you've kept me worrying about you for four days," Adora teased, brushing her fingers through Catra's hair. "On the other hand, I think you caught up on most of the sleep you lost during the war."

"Worth it, then." Catra leaned into Adora's hand, sighing. They sat in silence for several minutes, just enjoying each other's company.

"It was so weird, seeing all those different versions of you," Adora said thoughtfully. "You've changed *so* much."

"I *hope* I'm not the same person I was when I was *five*," Catra said with a scoff. Adora rolled her eyes, swatting Catra lightly.

"You're not the same person you were when you were fifteen, eighteen, or twenty either. I'm so proud of you."

"Damn right." Catra grinned, hazy gaze finally clearing to focus on Adora. "Hey, Adora?"

"Yeah?"

"Can you just… talk? I don't think I want to sleep again for a bit."

Adora brushed Catra's hair back, scritching the base of her ears. "Sure. Anything in particular you want me to say?"

"Anything."

She thought about it for a minute. “Swift Wind has been liberating another farm—”

“Maybe something else.”

End Notes

I missed deadline to edit this.

Okay not really, I missed deadline because it was my first flying solo paper but STILL it'd be cool if you reviewed.

Detail I didn't manage to get in:
1) Yes the sorcerer killed himself. Magical cyanide pill to try and force everyone's hand. They don't deserve a coven
2) Catra was the secondary target. Bow was the first choice because Queen's husband, but Catra is easier to get alone so they switched to her. She just has bad luck
3) There was no post-Prime short-haired Catra because that was the time in her life when she felt freest, and no literal or symbolic prisons in her life
4) Adult!Catra was in their room at Bright Moon because it's her metaphorical safe place, with the stipulation that she never knows what's going to happen when she leaves (i.e. portal Catra)
5) I am open to a short recovery sequel, but basically Catra is very scared to sleep and has nightmares for awhile after, you know, being cursed to sleep and trapped inside her head. Also people messing with her head is generally a touchy thing.

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